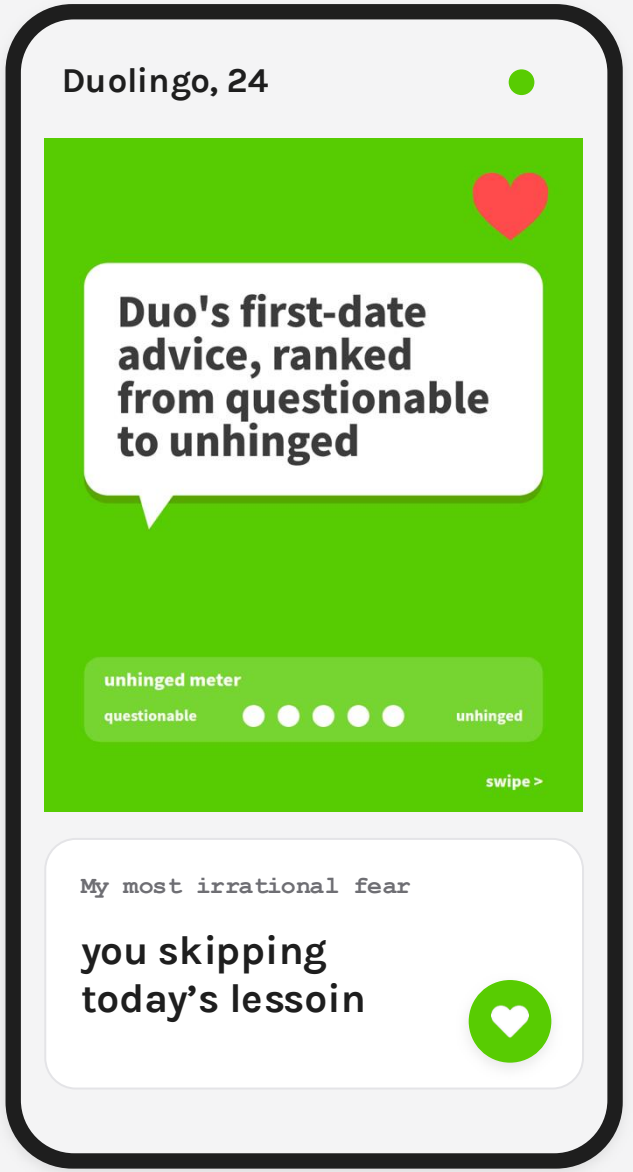
CONTENT PACKAGE

# Duolingo: Who's paying for the coffee?



Building the content package.

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 | 05 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Brief** | **Long-form** | **Headlines** | **Derivatives** | **Voice** |
| the reader | the article | the match | 8 posts, 5 channels | the rules |



BRIEF

# Written for one person: a beginner with a first date on Friday

I'm looking for

a beginner with a first date in two days, in the language they're learning.

Together, we could

attract people with a real reason to learn.

I won't shut up about

real-world communication, like knowing who's paying.

You'll know it's working when

they tap "Download Duolingo for free."

LONG-FORM

# Four bad ideas from Duo carry 18 genuinely useful phrases

**Headline**

How to compliment your date so they pay for the coffee (and 3 more first-date schemes)

**One-sentence argument**

You don't need fluency for a great first date in a new language. You need a handful of phrases and to know what they signal.

**Audience**

A1/A2 beginners with a first date coming up

**Channel**

Duolingo blog, 1,041 words

**The spine: one date, four schemes**

Compliment them so they pay for the coffee

 unhinged meter

Nod along when you understood nothing

 unhinged meter

Lock in date two without sounding desperate

 unhinged meter

Escape a bad date by blaming the owl

 unhinged meter

Spanish, Chinese, English. Full text in appendix.

HEADLINE TEST

# Four headlines got swiped left, and each found a new job

#2 swiped left

**Duo's first-date advice, ranked from questionable to unhinged**

New home: Instagram carousel cover

#3 swiped left

**Dear Duolingo: My date is Friday and I only know the word for apple**

New home: X post

#4 swiped left

**Flirt now, conjugate later**

New home: Email subject line

#5 swiped left

**You don't need to be fluent to date in a new language**

New home: The article's argument

**24**
headlines written

**5**
shortlisted

**1**
match

Six angles: curiosity, benefit, contrarian, question, number, blunt. Full list in appendix.

IT'S A MATCH

# Duo’s bold, selfish promise beats every other safe headline

The winner

## How to compliment your date so they pay for the coffee (and 3 more first-date schemes)

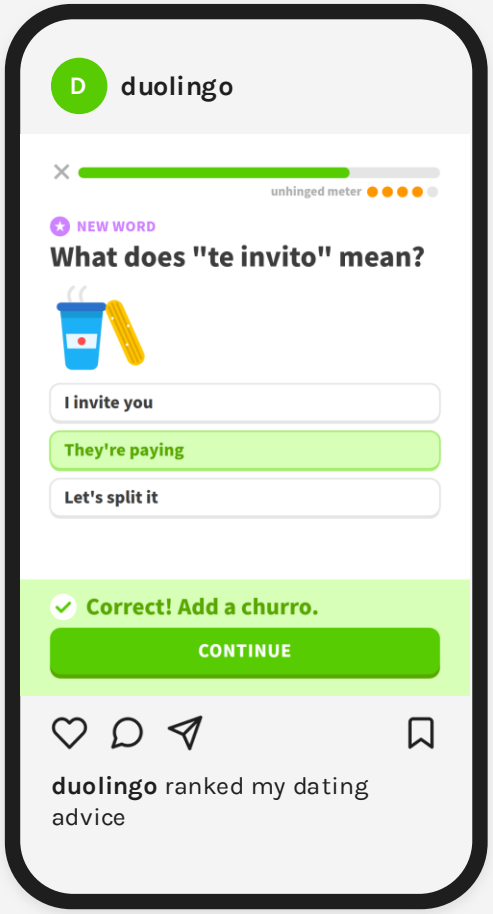


Why it won

It’s an intriguing headline that gives Duo a selfish stake in the story and makes the reader go, “Oh?” It uses the pattern behind the brand's biggest social posts, while still promising a concrete payoff a searcher can use.

DERIVATIVES

# Instagram and TikTok turn the schemes into a game




**Instagram: 6-slide carousel**

## Caption: "ranked my dating advice"

The article follows the date in order. The carousel re-sorts the same schemes from least to most unhinged and turns each into a mock lesson screen, Duo's signature Instagram format.



All six slides




**TikTok: 12-second script**

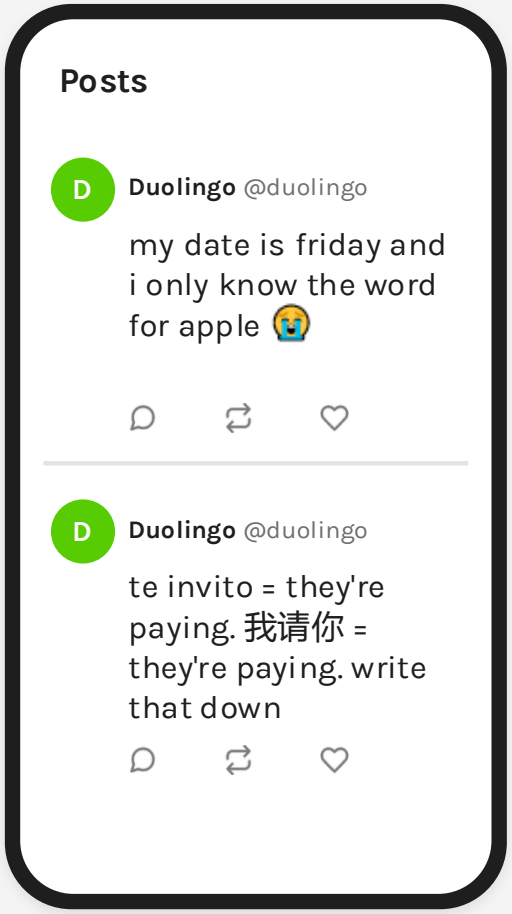
## Caption: "bad dates are universal, here's how to leave"

| | |
|---|---|
| 0 to 2s | Duo shoves his chair back: "sorry. i haven't done my lesson." |
| 2 to 11s | The exit line as word tiles in Chinese, Spanish, then English |
| 11 to 12s | "blame the owl. he doesn't mind." |

**Opens on the punchline, the exit itself.**

DERIVATIVES

# On X and LinkedIn, every post carries exactly one idea




X: 2 posts

### The panic

Duo as the dramatic main character. Lowercase, no sell, and it works even if no one clicks.

### The lesson

The article's best insight as a smug mini-lesson. Useful mini-lessons travel on X.

D

**Duolingo**
LinkedIn post

**Whoever invites pays.**

In Spanish, *te invito* means "I invite you." It also means the coffee's on them. 我请你 (wǒ qǐng nǐ) in Chinese works the same way. Say thank you and order whatever you want. If you're the one who said it, that's on you.

And if the night ends with "We should hang out sometime," that's the time to be bold. Say, "Can sometime be tomorrow?"

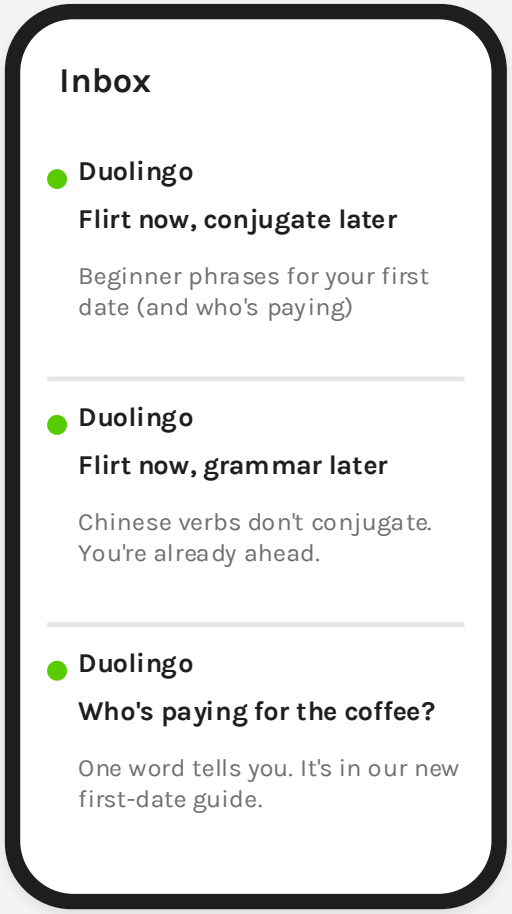
We wrote down every first-date phrase we'd only tell our bestie, in Spanish, Chinese, and English. Duo added four schemes. We rated them from questionable to unhinged.

Read it if you want a second date → [link]

**Opens on an opinion, then older-sister tips. No lecture on why.**

DERIVATIVES

# Rebuilt for each channel, down to the subject line




| Channel | Piece | Shaped for the channel |
|---|---|---|
| **Instagram** | 6-slide carousel | Re-sorted into a quiz, least to most unhinged |
| **TikTok** | 12-second script | Opens on the punchline |
| **X** | 2 posts | One idea each, lowercase, no sell |
| **LinkedIn** | 1 post | Opens on an opinion, then older-sister tips |
| **Email** | 3 subject lines | Earns the open, one per course audience |

**8 pieces, 5 channels**

**Voice-checked**

VOICE INPUTS

# Five rules keep Duo sounding like Duo on every channel

## Tone rules

**Duo is a person, not a brand.**

Crushes, grudges, drama. He wants to be a part of it all, and he's the main character.

**Older sister, not mom.**

Tell people what to do. Never explain why they should care. Or the consequences…

**Deadpan and current.**

No joke labels, no winking, emoji for tone only.

**Cheeky everywhere, softest with learners.**

Tease the learner. Never make them feel bad.

**The product is the punchline, never the pitch.**

Every post over 1M views had no sell.

## Voice samples: real copy we studied

X

when an ugly stranger calls you twin 😂😭 No Brand 🤦‍♀️🤚

10.5M views

X

no. and it's soccer

1,308 replies

Instagram

nein out of ten, would learn again

106K likes

TikTok

muy fake friend of you

264K likes

LinkedIn

Are we allowed to say this four-letter word on here?

Sep 22, 2026

Counter-example

Seven capsule pieces designed to elevate your wardrobe…

82 likes on 65K views

VOICE INPUTS

# Dealbreakers: fifteen things Duo never says

## Dealbreakers

### Words

- ✕ elevate
- ✕ unlock
- ✕ empower
- ✕ seamless
- ✕ leverage
- ✕ journey
- ✕ delve
- ✕ game-changer

### Constructions

- ✕ "It's not X, it's Y"
- ✕ em dashes
- ✕ "Whether you… or…"
- ✕ "Let's dive in"
- ✕ "Hot take:" and other joke labels
- ✕ justifying the why
- ✕ "We know that sounds bold…"

## Built with a brand-voice skill

**duolingo-copywriter, a Claude skill, trained on:**

- 99 hand-tagged X posts with performance data
- 6 blog posts and 5 LinkedIn posts
- 14 Instagram and TikTok screenshots
- A 12-mode humor codebook

## Rules added after human pushback

- Older sister, not mom
- Current 2026 humor, not millennial
- No em dashes, unless absolutely necessary

APPENDIX Long-form piece, page 1 of 5

# How to compliment your date so they pay for the coffee (and 3 more first-date schemes)

*Beginner phrases in Spanish, Chinese, and English for your first date, from the flirting to the check*

Cindy Ha | Sep 28, 2026

You matched. They said yes. The date is Friday, and your vocabulary in their language is mostly fruit, colors, and a surprising number of sentences about bears.

Good news: you don't need to be fluent to have a great first date in a new language. You need a handful of phrases and a sense of what they actually signal. A translation app can tell you what the words mean. It can't tell you that in Spanish and Chinese, offering to "invite" someone means you're paying.

So we asked Duo for dating advice. His ideas were…questionable. We kept his schemes and added the phrases (and the fair versions) that will actually help. Everything below works for beginners, and the English sections are written for anyone learning English who wants to know how these lines sound to a native speaker.

DOWNLOAD DUOLINGO FOR FREE

APPENDIX Long-form piece, page 2 of 5

## Scheme 1: Compliment them so they pay for the coffee

Unhinged meter

*Using flattery as a payment method.*

Duo's logic: flatter first, and the check takes care of itself. Start with a compliment that's simple and specific.

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | Me encanta tu sonrisa. | I love your smile. |
| **Chinese** | 你笑起来很好看。(Nǐ xiào qǐlái hěn hǎokàn.) | You look great when you smile. |
| **English** | I love your laugh. | "Love" is casual here. It doesn't mean "I love you," so it's safe on a first date. |

Then listen for the magic word. In Spanish, *Te invito a un café* literally means "I invite you to a coffee," but what it really means is "the coffee's on me." Chinese works the same way: 请 (qǐng) means "to invite," and 我请你 (Wǒ qǐng nǐ) means "It's my treat." If your date says either one, congratulations. Duo's plan worked.

In English, listen for "It's on me" or "My treat." If you hear "Let me get this," the right answer is a smile and a thank you, not a wrestling match over the check.

Now the fair version, which Duo only agreed to include after a long negotiation: offer to split.

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | ¿Pagamos a medias? | Should we split it? |
| **Chinese** | 我们AA吧? (Wǒmen AA ba?) | Let's split it? AA制 (AA zhì) is the everyday term for paying halves. |
| **English** | Want to split it? | Common and not rude. "Let's go Dutch" means the same thing but sounds a little old-fashioned. |

APPENDIX Long-form piece, page 3 of 5

# Scheme 2: Nod along when you understood nothing

Unhinged meter

*Questionable. Works right up until they ask you a question.*

Your date is telling a long, clearly hilarious story. You caught the word for "dog" and maybe "Tuesday." Duo's advice: react like you understood every word.

A few all-purpose reactions will buy you time:

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | ¡No me digas! | No way! (Literally "Don't tell me!") |
| **Chinese** | 真的吗？(Zhēn de ma?) | Really? |
| **English** | No way! | It sounds like disagreement, but it means "Wow, tell me more." |

The flaw in Duo's plan is that eventually they'll ask you a question. So here's what actually works: ask them to slow down. It shows you're trying, and most people are happy to help.

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | ¿Puedes hablar más despacio? | Can you speak more slowly? |
| **Chinese** | 你能说慢一点吗？(Nǐ néng shuō màn yìdiǎn ma?) | Can you speak a little slower? |
| **English** | Sorry, could you say that again? | Polite and normal. "What?" on its own can sound annoyed. |

APPENDIX Long-form piece, page 4 of 5

## Scheme 3: Lock in date two without sounding desperate

Unhinged meter

*Not unhinged. Just a little sad.*

Duo's strategy is to casually mention that you're free "literally any day." Please don't.

Be specific instead. "We should do this again" is easy to agree to and easy to forget. Naming a day turns it into a plan.

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | ¿Qué haces el sábado? | What are you doing Saturday? |
| **Chinese** | 你周六有空吗？(Nǐ zhōuliù yǒu kòng ma?) | Are you free Saturday? |
| **English** | Are you free Saturday? | Clear and confident. See the note on the right. |

A note for English learners: "We should hang out sometime" is one of the vaguest sentences in English. Sometimes it's a real invitation, and sometimes it's a polite way to end a conversation. If you want to see them again, name the day. If they answer "Yeah, sometime!" with no day attached, that might be your answer. (Sorry. )

Also, "hang out" can mean a date or just two friends getting food. If you want to be clear, "Can I take you out again?" leaves no doubt.

APPENDIX Long-form piece, page 5 of 5

# Scheme 4: Escape a bad date by blaming the owl

Unhinged meter 🟠🟠🟠🟠🟠

*Fully unhinged. Also technically true.*

Not every date is a love story. If it's time to go, Duo has the perfect excuse, and it happens to be true: you haven't done today's lesson.

| Language | Phrase | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **Spanish** | Lo siento, me tengo que ir. Todavía no hice mi lección. | Sorry, I have to go. I haven't done my lesson yet. (In Spain, you'll more often hear no he hecho.) |
| **Chinese** | 不好意思，我得走了。我今天还没打卡。(Bù hǎoyìsi, wǒ děi zǒu le. Wǒ jīntiān hái méi dǎkǎ.) | Sorry, I have to go. I haven't checked in today. 打卡 (dǎkǎ) literally means "punch the card," used for keeping up a daily habit, like a streak. |
| **English** | Sorry, I've gotta head out. | Casual for "I have to leave." Friendly, not rude. |

Is it a little dramatic? Yes. Will Duo vouch for you? Absolutely. 💚 He's been waiting all day.

And if the date went great, the same line works at the end of the night. Just follow it with Scheme 3.

## Your first date, handled

You don't need a perfect accent or a long list of verbs. A compliment, a way to handle the check, a way to keep up, and a way to make plans (or leave) will cover most first dates. Practice them out loud before Friday: to the mirror, to your dog, or to your houseplant, who won't judge your accent and won't ask you to split the check.

**And if your date says *te invito*? Order the pastry too ;)**

APPENDIX All 24 headlines, by angle

Top five marked by rank. The winner is #1.

## Curiosity

- The word that tells you who's paying on a first date
- Why te invito might be the most important phrase on a first date
- What your date really means by "We should hang out sometime"
- Things to say on a first date when your vocabulary is mostly fruit
- Your date said te invito. Order the pastry.

## Benefit

- First-date phrases for beginners in Spanish, Chinese, and English
- How to get through a first date in a language you're still learning
- 18 phrases that get you through a first date in a new language

## Contrarian

- #5 **You don't need to be fluent to date in a new language**
- Your translation app can't save your first date

## Question

- Who pays on a first date? Ask the language.
- Can you flirt in a language you just started learning?
- Dear Duolingo: How do I survive a first date in my new language?
- #3 **Dear Duolingo: My date is Friday and I only know the word for apple**

## Number

- 4 first-date schemes from Duo (and the phrases that actually work)
- 4 phrases to win the one for you on a first date
- #2 **Duo's first-date advice, ranked from questionable to unhinged**
- Zero fluency, one first date, four questionable schemes

## Blunt

- #1 **How to compliment your date so they pay for the coffee (and 3 more first-date schemes)**
- Blame the owl: how to leave a bad date in three languages
- #4 **Flirt now, conjugate later**
- Flirt now, grammar later
- First date, new language, zero fluency: a survival guide
- We asked Duo for dating advice. It went about as well as you'd think.

APPENDIX Sources and AI disclosure

## Voice sources (compiled and verified by me)

- @duolingo X export via TwExport: 161 posts, May 5 to Sep 25, 2026 (99 Duolingo-authored posts tagged)
- Duolingo blog: 6 posts, including Dear Duolingo (Aug 18 and Sep 15, 2026)
- Duolingo LinkedIn: 5 posts, Sep 21 to 28, 2026
- Duolingo Instagram and TikTok: 14 screenshots, Aug to Sep 2026

## AI disclosure

Researched and drafted with Claude (Anthropic).

Model used: Claude Opus 5.5.

Brand-voice skill (duolingo-copywriter) built and refined with Claude.

## Graphics

Carousel, TikTok frame, and slide art are original illustrations in a flat, Duolingo-inspired style.

No Duolingo characters or logos were reproduced; Duolingo's designers would swap Duo in.

Dating-app styling is inspired by Hinge, with no app logos or names.